# How to detect false or misleading information



# Not everything that circulates is true

Every day, we receive a great deal of information.

It reaches us through Instagram, TikTok, WhatsApp, X, Facebook, YouTube, the media, family groups or conversations with other people.

Some information is true.

Some is false.

And much of it is harder to identify because it mixes accurate information with false data, removes an important part of the context or uses real images to tell a story that does not match what we are seeing.

Detecting a false rumour is therefore not about

# Not everything that circulates is true

distrusting everything.

It is about learning to check before believing and sharing.

In the previous chapter, we learned to PAUSE and LOOK.

Now comes the third step in our AntiFake method:

CHECK.

# First: what is a false rumour?

A false rumour is false or misleading information that circulates as if it were true.

It can take the form of:

- a news story;
- a video;
- a photograph;
- a screenshot;
- an audio recording;
- a chart or statistic;
- a meme;

# First: what is a false rumour?

- a WhatsApp message;
- a social media post.

But one thing is important:

Information does not have to be completely false to mislead us.

A photograph can be real but have been taken in another country.

A piece of data can be correct but refer to a different year.

A video can be authentic but edited down.

# First: what is a false rumour?

A news story can describe a real event but leave out information essential to understanding it.

A screenshot can look as though it comes from a news outlet but have been manipulated.

And today an image, voice or video can also have been generated or modified with artificial intelligence.

The European Commission warns about these forms of manipulation: altered visual content, information taken out of context, impersonation of legitimate sources and messages designed to provoke strong emotions.

# Seven checks before sharing

# 1. Who publishes it?

The first question is very simple:

Who is giving me this information?

Data published by a public body is not the same as a screenshot with no identifiable origin.

Look for:

Who is the author?

Which media outlet, organisation or account publishes it?

Can we identify them?

Do they explain where they obtain their information?

# 1. Who publishes it?

If we cannot identify who is behind a piece of information, we should be more cautious.

# Warning sign

“Someone sent it to me.”

“People are saying it on WhatsApp.”

“I saw it on TikTok.”

This explains where we encountered the information, but not where it comes from.

# 2. Find the original source

This is probably one of the most important tools in AntiFake.

Do not stop at the screenshot.

Do not stop at the headline.

Do not stop at the fifteen-second video.

Ask:

Where did this information originally come from?

If a post says:

“According to a study…”

find the study.

# 2. Find the original source

If it says:

“According to official data…”

find the official data.

If it claims:

“The government will introduce a new benefit…”

find the body responsible for that benefit.

If it quotes someone:

“X said…”

try to find the complete statement.

The original source lets us see something that often

# 2. Find the original source

disappears when information is shared many times: the context.

# 3. Check the date

A real news story from five years ago can become disinformation if it is shared today as though it has just happened.

Always check:

When was it published?

When did the events take place?

Which year does the data refer to?

Has anything changed since then?

This is especially important when we discuss migration, social benefits, legislation, regularisation or population data.

# 3. Check the date

Rules change.

Data change.

Context changes too.

Information that was true can stop describing the current situation accurately.

# 4. Look for other sources reporting the same thing

If information is important, we can probably find more information about it.

Do not simply look for another page repeating exactly the same text.

Look for sources that are independent of one another.

For example:

- public bodies;
- official statistics;
- media outlets with identifiable authors and editorial

# 4. Look for other sources reporting the same thing

standards;

- universities or research centres;

- specialist organisations;

- independent fact-checkers.

The European Commission recommends checking whether information is supported by several reliable sources and consulting fact-checkers when there are doubts.

But be careful:

Ten websites repeating the same information are

# 4. Look for other sources reporting the same thing

not necessarily ten sources.

They may all be copying a single false claim.

We need to find where the information comes from.

# 5. Do not stop at the headline

Headlines are designed to attract our attention.

Sometimes they greatly simplify information.

At other times, a screenshot shows only the headline and removes the rest of the story.

So:

Open the article.

Read beyond the headline.

Find the data supporting the claim.

Check whether the content really says the same thing as the headline.

# 5. Do not stop at the headline

And ask yourself:

What do I know after reading the full information that I did not know when I had only seen the headline?

# 6. Check photographs and videos

A real photograph can also lie.

Or, more precisely:

we can lie by using a real photograph.

Imagine a photograph of a large fight.

The photograph is authentic.

But it was taken in another country five years ago.

Someone publishes it today with the text:

“This is happening right now in Barcelona.”

The photograph has not been manipulated.

# 6. Check photographs and videos

What has been manipulated is the context.

Reverse image search is a very useful tool. It allows you to search for a photograph to check whether it has appeared on the internet before and in what context. UNESCO includes this technique among the tools for verifying visual content.

With a video, we can ask:

Who published it first?

When?

Where was it recorded?

# 6. Check photographs and videos

Is it complete, or are we only seeing a fragment?

Is there an earlier version?

Do other sources show the same event?

With content generated or manipulated using AI, we should not rely only on whether it “looks strange”. We should look for its provenance and confirmation from reliable sources. The European Commission includes deepfakes among the forms of manipulation we need to learn to recognise.

# 7. Pay attention to data and charts

Numbers can give us a sense of certainty.

But data need context.

Imagine reading:

“Crimes committed by foreigners have increased by 20%.”

Before reaching a conclusion, we need to ask:

Who published this data?

Which territory are we talking about?

Which period?

What exactly is being counted?

# 7. Pay attention to data and charts

Are we discussing reports, arrests, convictions or something else?

What are the absolute numbers?

What is it being compared with?

Has the population also changed during this period?

We are not saying that this particular claim is true or false.

We are doing something more important:

not reaching a conclusion until we have enough information to interpret the data.

# When a news story confirms exactly what we already thought

There is another warning sign that is not on the screen.

It is in us.

We all have prior ideas about the world.

So when information confirms exactly something we already thought, we may feel less need to check it.

If we think that a particular group receives many benefits and a news story arrives confirming this, we may share it more quickly.

# When a news story confirms exactly what we already thought

AntiFake suggests doing the opposite:

The more a piece of information confirms what I already thought, the more important it is to check it.

We do not only verify what seems absurd.

We must also verify what we would like to be true.

# What if I cannot verify it?

Sometimes we will not find the answer.

We do not know where the photograph comes from.

We cannot find the study.

We cannot identify the author.

The sources contradict one another.

Or we simply do not have time to investigate.

In this situation, we can still make a responsible decision:

I do not know. So I will not share it as though I do.

Not sharing unverified information is also a way to

# What if I cannot verify it?

slow disinformation. UNESCO recommends avoiding the reproduction of unverified content, and the European Commission advises against sharing when the origin or reliability of information cannot be established.

# Let us try an example

Imagine receiving this WhatsApp message:

“NEW €600 BENEFIT FOR IMMIGRANTS. The media are not reporting it. Share before it gets deleted.”

We do not yet know whether it is true or false.

# 1. PAUSE

Do not forward it.

# 2. LOOK

Who sends it?

Is a responsible body identified?

Is there a link?

Is the message trying to create urgency?

# 3. CHECK

Search for the exact name of the benefit.

Consult the website of the administration supposedly providing it.

Check eligibility requirements and beneficiaries.

Look for a fact-check of the message.

Check the date.

# 4. THINK

Why does it say “for immigrants”?

Is it really a benefit available exclusively on the basis of origin?

Or are there financial, family, administrative or residency requirements that the message is hiding?

What narrative does this way of presenting the information construct?

# 5. ACT

If it is false, do not share it.

If someone sent it to you, you can explain what you found and provide the correct source.

# The AntiFake questions

When you have doubts, remember:

WHO SAYS IT?

WHERE DOES IT COME FROM?

WHEN IS IT FROM?

WHO ELSE CONFIRMS IT?

WHAT MIGHT BE MISSING?

We do not need to become investigative journalists.

We need to develop a habit:

PAUSE before sharing and CHECK before accepting information as true.